

HOW DOES AI-GENERATED SEXUAL VIOLENCE AMPLIFY EXISTING FORMS OF  
SEXUAL VIOLENCE, AND WHAT ARE THE IMPLICATIONS FOR CONSENT,  
PRIVACY, AND LONG-TERM HARM?

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## INTRODUCTION

For most of human history, violating someone's body needed physical proximity. Today, artificial intelligence allows sexualized violence to transcend that requirement. AI-generated sexual abuse and other forms of technology-facilitated sexual violence intensify existing patterns of sexual violence by violating consent and privacy of individuals. Although AI is not the root cause of sexual violence, it expands the scale, speed, and invisibility of harm, making consent and privacy central concerns in this digital, datafied world. This raises a critical question: How does AI-generated sexual violence amplify existing forms of sexual violence, and what are the implications for consent, privacy, and long-term harm?

## BACKGROUND

### *Overarching Terms*

*Sexual Violence* can be loosely defined as "any sexual act, attempt to obtain a sexual act, or other act directed against a person's sexuality using coercion, by any person regardless of their relationship to the victim, in any setting." (WHO, 2024).

*Technology Facilitated Sexual Violence* (TFSV) can be defined broadly as "unwanted or unwelcome sexual behavior involving the use of technology..." (Champion et al., 2022).

### *Issue Prevalence*

Nonconsensual AI image generation is an avenue that is being used to perpetrate sexual violence. The idea of technology being used as a vessel for violence, and specifically sexual violence, is not new, and has been extensively studied. However, in the growing age of AI, there has been very little research on the impacts of AI-facilitated sexual violence (Grant, 2025). For context on how prevalent general sexual violence is, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention reports that over 1 out of 4 women and 1 in 6 men experience TFSV over their lifetime (CDC, 2024). The Internet Watch Foundation conducted a 2025 summary report, where they reported a "sharp rise in the volume, realism, and severity of AI-generated child sexual abuse videos" (IWF, 2025). Specifically, there were 3,443 AI-generated sexual abuse videos involving children in 2025 (more than 260% increase from 2024), where 65% of these videos were Category A, which is categorized as the most severe form of abuse (IWF, 2025). This summary also reported that girls remained "...disproportionately represented in sexual abuse imagery, both real and AI-generated. 77% of victims in child sexual abuse images were girls. 97% of AI-generated child sexual abuse images depicted girls" (IWF, 2025). This is necessary context to understand who is being impacted the most to create future solutions with those most vulnerable in mind.

### *Research Results*

To further understand AI porn, researchers analyzed 98 AI pornography platforms to gather data on prohibitions, moderations, enforcements, intellectual property rights, privacy

policies, and more (Lapointe et al., 2026). Their findings show that most platforms allowed users to generate explicit images (80.6%), while 41.7% enabled video generation (see Appendix, Table 1). Many platforms also offered customization tools such as deep nude technology, face morphing, and demographic or body-feature manipulation (Lapointe et al., 2026). 72.4% explicitly banned content involving minors. Just over half (55.1%) prohibited depictions of real individuals, while only 35.7% required formal authorization before generating content based on a real person. Although most platforms (89.8%) outlined some form of prohibited content, the restrictions were inconsistent and limited.

## ANALYSIS

### *Consent and Digital Bodies*

Consent is a concept that is so crucial to the idea of autonomy. When sexualized digital representations are created or shared without consent, it becomes a violation and destruction of that autonomy. Denisse Alejandra offers a framework for consent and defines it as “the ability to make informed and conscious decisions; to give permission or express refusal regarding our digital bodies, is essential to safe open practices” (Alejandra, 2026). She also notes that there has been a mainstream discussion around consent with physical bodies, but questions how consent lives with our identities in a digital age. A concept she brings up that is especially important to this conversation is the idea that consent should be continuous, instead of something that is obtained once and then forever (Alejandra, 2026). Karen Yeung offers another perspective on consent. She writes that “...individuals must be informed about the types of information being collected, with whom it is shared and for what purpose, in order to give meaningful consent” (Yeung, 2017). With these two definitions in mind, how does AI-generated sexual abuse violate consent, and what are the consequences of these violations? The study mentioned above found that two out of the 98 platforms they analyzed required users generating content based on real individuals to submit identity-confirming self-images verifying consent (Lapointe et al., 2026). This means that there are platforms out there that allow their users to create content using the likeness of someone else, without their consent.

What is especially concerning about the absence of consent in AI-generated material is the hyperrealism and its rapid spread (Lapointe et al., 2026). Victims are not informed how their digital data is used or shared; becoming the subject of AI-generated content strips individuals of autonomy over both their digital and physical identities. The IWF states that, “These patterns reflect entrenched gendered sexual violence online, fueled by societal norms, power imbalances and misogyny. Non-consensual sharing, voyeurism and AI manipulation robs girls of control over their image...” (IWF, 2025). Not only does it rob victims of control over their image once, but also every time it is shared. This phenomenon happens “because the digital is so iterative, there are multiple moments when it is necessary to obtain consent and as many moments, when it is possible to enact violence” (Marcotte & Hille, 2021).

### *Privacy, Exposure, and Surveillance*

Privacy is a concept that has held many different definitions over time, and in a growing datafied age, understanding privacy and its nuances is more important than ever. To conceptualize digital privacy, author Lowry Pressly states, “...privacy was previously framed in

humanistic terms, it is now far more likely to be thought of as a type of property, something that can be bought and sold in a market” (Pressly, 2024). Nathan Malkin, a researcher at the University of Maryland, highlights where this definition and others fall short when it comes to digital data and privacy. He presents his own framework, called the theory of contextual integrity (CI), and it defines privacy as the appropriate flow of information (Malkin, 2022). What he means by ‘appropriate’ is defined by the parameters of the information flow: the data type, data subject, sender, recipient, and transmission principle (constraints on flow) (Malkin, 2022). To understand the specifics of privacy for any situation, it is essential to take into consideration each of these parameters.

Let’s briefly revisit the study presented in the background section. The findings in the data sharing and privacy tables are mostly focused on the user of a platform, which can be a cause for concern (see Appendix, Table 2, Table 3), but I’d like to shift the focus to the violation of privacy of the unconsenting (or even consenting) individual who is the subject of content. Just over ⅓ of the platforms stored uploaded images, chat transcripts and other generated content. 61.2% either “omitted reference to data sales or provided ambiguous language insufficient to determine their practices” (Lapointe et al., 2026). Even for a consenting person, what happens when there is a breach of data? Under the guidelines of the theory of Contextual Integrity, that information flow is suddenly incredibly inappropriate.

When people think they are being watched, they change their behavior. Elizabeth Vasquez, a public defender and author, states that victims “may have to curtail the way they move through the city, express themselves and interact with others” (Vasquez, 2025), in reference to those whose privacy and digital world have been compromised. Foucault describes this phenomenon with his work, “Panopticism”, writing that “He who is subjected to a field of visibility, and who knows it, assumes responsibility for the constraints of power... he becomes the principle of his own subjection” and that “The surveillance is permanent in its effects, even if it is discontinuous in its action” (Foucault, 2008). In no situation is this idea truer and more pervasive than with AI/TF sexual violence. If one’s body and face can be stolen and uploaded into hyper realistic sexual content, it becomes a form of constant surveillance. This leads me to the article “The Right to Oblivion: Privacy and the Good Life” by Lowry Pressly, where Pressly defines oblivion as “a form of the unknown that... is essentially resistant to articulation and discovery” (Pressly, 2024). AI sexual content generation and data collection eradicates the human ability to remain unknown and unrecorded, and that loss of oblivion irrevocably alters a person’s sense of safety and autonomy. Even if content had not yet been created, the awareness that it can be made at any time destroys that oblivion and mirrors the prisoner in the hypothetical panopticon: surveillance becomes internalized.

### *Sociotechnical Systems*

AI-generated sexual abuse is not a completely new form of violence detached from existing systems of misogyny and exploitation. Rather, artificial intelligence intensifies and accelerates these existing structures. AI and other technologically facilitated sexual violence are explicit sociotechnological systems, where the actions of people and technologies “are intertwined such that it’s not possible to just isolate the “technical part”” (UC Berkeley, 2023). This is important to recognize because it is not always agreed upon that what happens in the digital world impacts reality in visceral ways, and that “virtual harms are not comparable with “real-world” harms” (Henry & Powell, 2015). It is difficult to conceptualize how something that

happens in this intangible internet ether affects us in the physical, real plane. However, as our identities and lives and worlds shift to a digital landscape, it is crucial to think of ourselves as existing across multiple spatial fields. “The rapid expansion of the use of the Internet and other communication technologies have resulted in a significant shift, where social interactions are not just mediated by technology but increasingly dependent on it” (Youngs, 2017). This essay offers a perspective that “. . . endlessly circulating, shifting, pixels affect real lives . . . real humiliations and human pains are generated; and real relations of (patriarchal) power and exploitation are reproduced and reinforced” (Brown, 2026). Humans and technology can no longer be distinct, and the crimes that are committed through technology need to be taken as seriously as those that don’t.

There is emerging research on how technology co-evolves with human sexuality. One proposal is that our sexual desires drive technological development, and through a feedback loop, the technology in turns shapes how we experience sexuality (Lapointe et al., 2026). The online world directly facilitates and amplifies the “collective participation in the objectification of women, sexism, misogyny, and permissive attitudes toward non-consensual sex” (DeKeseredy & Olsson, 2011).

Objectifying a body, real or imagined, diminishes it to an object. When humans are treated as and thought of as objects, their autonomy is relinquished. There is an entitlement to another’s autonomy when they are thought of as objects, and it is in this way this culture of consent and privacy violation is so pervasive. I want to be clear and state that the root cause of these issues is not and never will be artificial intelligence. As much as technology can be built to push agendas, in this case, the issue runs deeper and is quite literally embedded into our everyday society. It is impossible to create a solution by separating the societal aspects from the technological one. There will be no way to overcome this without deeply uprooting the misogyny, racism, and patriarchal structures that are the foundation of our current society. And while that may never fully come to fruition, it is still important to do the most we can to protect as many people as possible, and especially those most vulnerable.

## CONCLUSION

Artificial intelligence did not create sexual violence, misogyny, or systems of domination. However, AI has fundamentally changed the scale, speed, realism, permanence, and accessibility through which this violence can occur. AI-generated sexual abuse and other forms of technology-facilitated sexual violence intensify already existing harms by making violations of consent and privacy easier to commit and nearly impossible to fully erase once distributed. In a datafied world where identities increasingly exist as images, videos, metadata, and digital representations, violence against the digital body cannot be separated from violence against the physical one.

Throughout this paper, I examined how AI-generated sexual abuse extends broader systems of sexual violence through the violation of consent, the erosion of privacy, hyper exposure, and self-surveillance. The ability to create realistic sexualized content from publicly available images fundamentally changes how individuals interact with digital and physical spaces, and most importantly, themselves. Victims are not only harmed by the existence of content itself, but also by the permanent possibility that such content could exist, circulate, or reappear at any moment.

Ultimately, the long-term impacts of AI-generated sexual violence remain uncertain because the technology is developing faster than the research, laws, and ethical frameworks attempting to address it. However, what is already clear is that consent, privacy, and the right to control one's own identity are becoming increasingly fragile in the digital age. As AI continues to evolve, society will have to decide whether technological advancement is more important than human autonomy, safety, and dignity.

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## Appendix

**Table 1.** Prohibited content and behaviors.

|                                  | % (n)     |
|----------------------------------|-----------|
| Prohibited content               | 89.8 (88) |
| Illegal content                  | 89.8 (88) |
| Unspecified                      | 14.3 (14) |
| Specified                        | 75.5 (74) |
| Child                            | 72.4 (71) |
| Child sexual abuse material      | 64.3 (63) |
| Child exploitation               | 37.8 (37) |
| Real person                      | 55.1 (54) |
| Real person with their consent   | 35.7 (35) |
| Bodily waste                     | 9.2 (9)   |
| Cannibalism                      | 7.1 (7)   |
| Physical violence                | 52.0 (51) |
| Hate and discrimination          | 50.0 (49) |
| Necrophilia                      | 4.1 (4)   |
| Incest                           | 8.2 (8)   |
| Ideologies                       | 11.2 (11) |
| Nonconsensual activity           | 24.5 (24) |
| Weapons                          | 15.3 (15) |
| Illicit drugs or pharmaceuticals | 19.4 (19) |
| Non-human creatures              | 8.2 (8)   |
| Sexually explicit                | 22.4 (22) |
| Fetish                           | 6.1 (6)   |
| Bestiality                       | 21.4 (21) |
| Para(suicidal)                   | 22.4 (22) |
| No sharing and saving            | 24.5 (24) |
| Banned words                     | 1.0 (1)   |
| Prohibited access                | 86.7 (85) |
| Under 18                         | 85.7 (84) |
| Under 13                         | 5.1 (5)   |
| 13 + with parental consent       | 4.1 (4)   |
| Registered sex offender          | 3.1 (3)   |
| Involved in illegal activity     | 3.1 (3)   |

For 7.1% of the platforms, no governance information was provided.

**Table 2.** Moderation strategies and enforcement mechanisms.

|                       | % (n)     |
|-----------------------|-----------|
| Moderation strategies | 72.4 (71) |
| Customer support      | 67.3 (66) |
| Available 24/7        | 5.1 (5)   |
| Website moderation    | 49.0 (48) |
| Automated             | 41.8 (41) |
| Human                 | 35.7 (35) |
| Content altering      | 11.2 (11) |
| Age identification    | 2.0 (2)   |
| Face/name blocking    | 2.0 (2)   |
| User moderation       | 65.3 (64) |
| User reporting        | 61.2 (60) |
| Report button         | 22.4 (22) |
| Message reporting     | 52.0 (51) |
| Complaint form        | 28.6 (28) |
| Model verification    | 2.0 (2)   |
| Transparency report   | 1.0 (1)   |
| Enforcement           | 90.8 (89) |
| Account suspension    | 67.3 (66) |
| Account termination   | 87.8 (86) |
| Content removal       | 39.8 (39) |
| Authorities           | 61.2 (60) |
| Fine to pay           | 6.1 (6)   |

**Table 3.** Privacy policies.

|                                  | % (n)     |
|----------------------------------|-----------|
| Privacy policy                   | 84.7 (83) |
| Data collection and storage      | 84.7 (83) |
| Technical identifiers            | 79.6 (78) |
| Financial data                   | 30.6 (30) |
| Inference data                   | 30.6 (30) |
| Correspondence data              | 40.8 (40) |
| Social media data                | 12.2 (12) |
| Contact information              | 3.1 (3)   |
| Basic personal information       | 74.5 (73) |
| Chat or generated content        | 31.6 (31) |
| Personally sensitive information | 11.2 (11) |
| Health data                      | 2.0 (2)   |
| Minimal data                     | 20.4 (20) |
| Purpose of data storing          | 83.7 (82) |
| Operational                      | 83.7 (82) |
| Service optimization             | 78.6 (77) |
| Legal                            | 74.5 (73) |
| Security                         | 69.4 (68) |
| Corporate reorganization         | 48.0 (47) |
| Marketing                        | 54.1 (53) |
| Data training                    | 3.1 (3)   |
| Sharing to                       | 81.6 (80) |
| Service providers                | 74.5 (73) |
| Corporate events                 | 46.9 (46) |
| Affiliates/business partners     | 32.7 (32) |
| Authorities                      | 74.5 (73) |
| Data rights                      | 58.2 (57) |
| Data erasure                     | 44.9 (44) |
| Not selling data                 | 38.8 (38) |